LESSON 13: RESTS

If a note is ringing out, it is sustained. If a note is prevented from ringing out, it is rested. During a rested note, there should be zero noise coming from your guitar. Here are the symbols used for musical rests:

	Value	*Note Symbol*	*Rest Symbol*
Whole Note	4 beats	𝅝	𝄻
Half Note	2 beats	𝅗𝅥	𝄼
Quarter Note	1 Beat	𝅘𝅥	𝄽
Eighth Note	1/2 beat (two notes per beat)	𝅘𝅥𝅮	𝄾

Three Ways to Rest a Chord

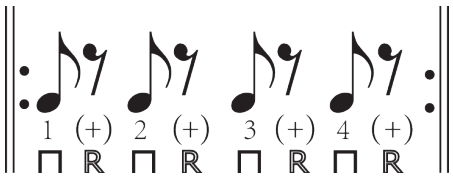
There are several techniques that guitarists use to create rests. Here are three popular methods:

1. Once a chord is ringing out, "karate chop" the strings with the ridge of your picking hand (that's the edge of your palm, closest to your pinkie. Performed correctly, this can position your pick so it's ready for a downstrum.

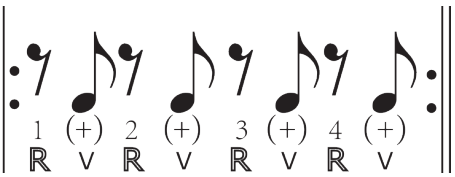
2. Strike the strings with the **opposite** side of your hand, using the length of your thumb's edge to cover all the strings. This can position the pick in a spot where it is ready to perform an upstroke.

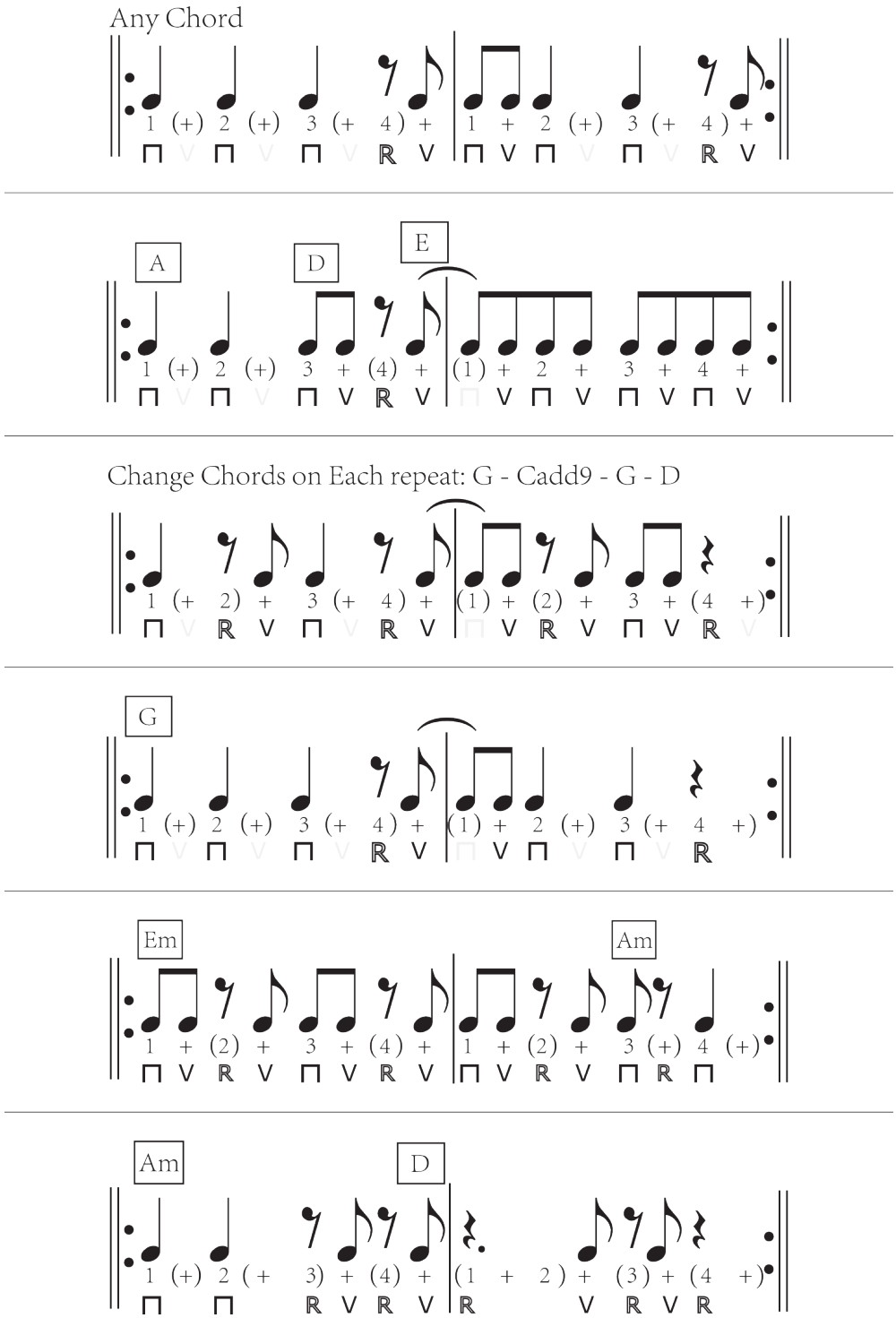
3. You can perform a "percussive rest" by getting your hand into a palm-mute position just before a strum. Strum down, but allow your right hand palm (pinkie side) to contact and press against the strings BEFORE the pick strikes. Unlike a regular palm mute, we don't want any notes ringing out, so ensure your hand is touching the strings farther from the bridge and closer to the pickups or sound hole. This will limit your ability to strum all the strings, so aim for just a few low notes.

Different rhythm patterns will require the use of different techniques, since some rests will occur before upstrokes and others will occur before downstrokes. Practice all three techniques with the following rhythm patterns, and don't worry about timing just now. Focus on the getting the technique smooth and comfortable — at first, it can be very tricky and even a bit painful!



The "R" symbol will be used for now to represent a rest



Exercises

Here are six different rhythm patterns you should aim to master. Practice each one using different resting techniques. Consider practicing each rhythm with a single chord, then add in the chord changes.